

Part 3

There is a certain kind of character and story I have always found myself drawn toward: the outsider, the cynic, the person who has been hurt or transformed by the world but refuses to completely surrender to it. That is why John Constantine, Kamen Rider, Bloodborne, and Hotline Miami resonate with me in ways that go beyond simply enjoying their stories.

Constantine is perhaps the clearest example. His cynicism, stubbornness, loneliness, and self-destructive tendencies feel familiar. Getting dumped over text, becoming distant from people my age, and picking up Constantine's coping mechanism/habit shaped how I see myself and other people. I became more skeptical of people and increasingly uncomfortable with what I saw as superficiality. Yet I still have a small circle of confidants whom I genuinely trust. With them, I can have long conversations and be honest rather than perform a version of myself.

That contrast—keeping most people at arm's length while valuing a few genuine relationships—is something I see throughout the characters I gravitate toward.

Shin Kamen Rider embodies another side of this. Takeshi Hongo is transformed into something frightening and unnatural, yet chooses to use that power to protect others. His heroism comes from refusing to let what was done to him determine what he becomes. Kamen Rider W, particularly Kamen Rider Skull, represents another form of that same idea. Skull is worn down and flawed, but still willing to stand against the ugliness around him. His heroism feels less like idealism and more like accepting that someone has to step forward.

MetsubouJinrai.net represents a darker variation. Their malice born from the Ark, but their story eventually becomes more complicated than simple villainy. Their transition toward anti-heroism reflects something I find compelling: being shaped by Malice does not necessarily determine what you ultimately become.

Bloodborne expresses these ideas through horror. Its world is built around isolation, madness, violence, obsession, and the pursuit of truths that perhaps should never have been discovered. Yet the Hunter continues forward despite having almost no certainty about what lies ahead. There is no guarantee that understanding the world will make it better. You simply keep going.

Then there is Hotline Miami, which adds another layer: questioning identity itself. Its violence is deliberately uncomfortable, and its strange conversations constantly challenge the player with questions about motivation and reality. “Do you like hurting other people?” “Where are you right now?” “Why are we having this conversation?” These questions are unsettling because they force you to question not only what is happening, but who you are within it.

That connects with the skepticism I have developed toward people and appearances. I often find myself wondering what lies beneath someone's behavior, whether people are being genuine, and why they act the way they do.

Ultimately, that is what connects these for me. They are not stories about perfect people. They are about people who are damaged, isolated, cynical, manipulated, transformed, or burdened by circumstances—and who still have to decide what they will become. Maybe that is why I relate to them. I don't necessarily see myself as a hero. I simply recognize something in characters who look at a broken, absurd, or incomprehensible world and, despite everything, keep walking forward.